



INTERVIEWED & PHOTOGRAPHED
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Living with a pogreb

In conversation with my grandparents
about food, ecological produce
and changing times

Babushka wants to show me something.

We open a wooden door and step into a spacious shed. The first room contains shovels; some with dried soil still clinging to their metal blades, and some wider plastic shovels for snow, a children’s sled is standing at the entrance, carpets hanging for later use, buckets of different sizes, tools whose purposes I don’t know all of. Everything seems to have its place. It is not a storage of unused things, but rather an active shed and reality that is maintained.



We move into the second room. More tools. *Veniki* (dried birch branches) for the *banya*. Wooden planks leaning on the wall. Babushka shifts my focus to the floor. Two wooden flaps lie next to each other. She lifts one, pulls out a jacket, then removes a second flap. Underneath is a dark opening in the ground.

This is my grandparents’ *pogreb*.



At first, the *pogreb* seems to be only a hole. I feel an instinctive fear of falling into it. Babushka does not hesitate. She pulls over a heavy wooden ladder just under three meters in height, lowers it into the hole, and climbs down. All of this with an ease of habit. I stay above, holding an electric lamp, shining light into the darkness for her.

In Russia, especially in rural and semi-rural areas, *pogrebs* have historically been essential infrastructure. They are still widely used by pensioners, people who grew up with them, and people who cannot or do not want to rely entirely on store-bought food. It seems to me to be an autonomous, ecological lifestyle that I can learn from.

Having grown up in Berlin, I am intrigued by everything surrounding my grandparents' pogreb. I decided to speak with them - Babushka and Dedushka - about it. In this article I lay out the main points I take from our conversation. Rather than a know-how of how to use a pogreb, I dissect the main assumptions I had coming into this project and that got challenged or confirmed in our conversation. I share my impulses and reflect on my own romanticized view of the pogreb.

Assumption 1.
My grandparents use the pogreb for ecological reasons.

Assumption 2.
Pogreb maintenance and knowledge are declining.

Assumption 3.
My grandparents are sad that the younger generation does not know how to maintain a pogreb anymore.



We are in Otchor, the Ural region of Russia. In winter.

Have you always lived with a pogreb?

“Yes. All my life. In childhood. And later too.” For Babushka, the pogreb is not an innovation or a lifestyle choice. It is something she grew up with and continues to uphold. Also called *podval* or *yama*, it can be translated as a root cellar. It is a temperature-stable underground storage space used to preserve vegetables, fruits, and homemade preserves through the winter. The pogreb is far from a gimmick. For Babushka and Dedushka, and many older people in rural Russia, it is a means of surviving the long and brutal winters that is cared for all year round. In fall, the pogreb is filled so it can preserve throughout the winter. In summer it is emptied, cleaned, and disinfected.

“I wouldn’t say I’m a big gardener or a true enthusiast.”

Why do you use a pogreb, Babushka?

“Because it’s convenient for storing vegetables and preserves here. Things that can be prepared for future use. In the summer, for example, there are lots of apples. You need to make compotes, jams, and so on. Pick mushrooms, pickle vegetables, and marinate them. Place all of this in a pit and cellar; it keeps well; the temperature there is always constant, so it doesn’t spoil. Furthermore, fresh vegetables such as potatoes, carrots, beets, and so on are preserved throughout the winter, which is very convenient. Because we eat a lot of vegetables and things grown and gathered in the forest. And this allows us to preserve and use them. Previously, none of this was sold. And so people prepared a lot. Everything is for sale now. It’s easy to go buy potatoes, then carrots, and that’s it. But that costs money. A lot of it. And so for people who aren’t very wealthy, this is one way to save money. That’s one thing. But for many people it’s still a hobby; they get pleasure from the fact that they can grow flowers, fruits, and vegetables on the land. This is a great activity, especially for pensioners, and it also saves money, allowing you to grow what you want, not what you’ll have to buy, whether you have it or not.”

